

KEY TOPIC 1 COURSE TEXTBOOK • CHRONOLOGICAL ENQUIRY SEQUENCE • 1558–1569**QUEEN, GOVERNMENT AND RELIGION, 1558–1569***From Accession Crisis and the 1559 Religious Settlement to the Arrival of Mary, Queen of Scots***ARCHIVAL PRIMARY RECORD • 15 JANUARY 1559****NPG-LONDON / ACC-1559-CORONATION****The Coronation Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I, Westminster Abbey**

Elizabeth I enthroned in cloth of gold robes patterned with Tudor roses and French fleurs-de-lis, bearing the royal orb and sceptre, symbolising sovereign majesty and the restoration of royal independence.

ARCHIVAL PRIMARY RECORD

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 MASTER ARCHIVE

PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY SPECIFICATION CONTENT**KEY TOPIC 1 COVERAGE MATRIX****1.1 ACCESSION (1558)**

- Social hierarchy & **Great Chain of Being**; Court, Privy Council & Parliament.
- Legitimacy doubts, 16th-century gender prejudice & the **marriage dilemma**.
- Crown debt of **£300,000**, debasement & Antwerp moneylenders.
- Foreign threats: loss of Calais, Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis & **Auld Alliance**.
- Fiscal reform: William Cecil, Crown land sales & cutting royal expenditures.

1.1 CHRONOLOGICAL CAUSAL FLOW

Nov 1558: Accession of Elizabeth I
 ↓
Nov 1558: Cecil Appointed Principal Secretary
 ↓
Jan 1559: Coronation in Westminster Abbey
 ↓
Apr 1559: Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis (Calais lost)

CORE DISCIPLINARY FOCUS

Royal Prerogative vs Crown Debt •
 Exam Link: Q1 Feature / Q2 Causation

1.2 SETTLEMENT (1559)

- Religious divisions: Catholic North/West vs Protestant South-East.
- **Act of Supremacy:** Elizabeth adopts title of **Supreme Governor**.
- **Act of Uniformity:** 1559 Prayer Book, ambiguous communion & 1s recusancy fine.
- **Royal Injunctions**, nationwide visitations & clerical licensing.
- Church courts as instruments of social control, morality & community cohesion.

1.2 CHRONOLOGICAL CAUSAL FLOW

Feb 1559: Commons Debates Religious Bills
 ↓
Apr 1559: Acts of Supremacy & Uniformity
 ↓
Summer 1559: Royal Injunctions Issued
 ↓
1559–60: Nationwide Episcopal Visitations

CORE DISCIPLINARY FOCUS

Legislative Via Media Compromise •
 Exam Link: Q1 Feature / Q3 Essay

1.3 CHALLENGES

- Puritan challenge: **Crucifix Controversy** & 1566 **Vestment Controversy**.
- Catholic challenge: northern nobility recusancy & 1566 Papal decree.
- European Counter-Reformation: Council of Trent & **Douai seminary (1568)**.
- Spanish threat in Netherlands: Duke of Alba's 50,000 veteran troops.
- **Papal Bull (1570):** *Regnans in Excelsis* excommunication & 1571 Treasons Act.

1.3 CHRONOLOGICAL CAUSAL FLOW

1563: Thirty-Nine Articles of Faith
 ↓
Mar 1566: Parker's Book of Advertisements
 ↓
1567: Alba's Army Deployed to Netherlands
 ↓
1568: Douai Seminary College Founded

CORE DISCIPLINARY FOCUS

Puritan Vestments & Counter-Reformation • Exam Link: Q2 Causation / Q3 Essay

1.4 MARY STUART (1568–69)

- Dynastic claim: Catholic claimant, Scottish scandal & Darnley's murder.
- Escape from Lochleven & arrival at **Workington, Cumberland (May 1568)**.
- Elizabeth's constitutional dilemma: the four fatal options regarding Mary.
- **Conference of York (1568–69):** Casket Letters & "not proven" verdict.
- Indefinite English captivity & catalyst for the **1569 Northern Revolt**.

1.4 CHRONOLOGICAL CAUSAL FLOW

Feb 1567: Darnley Murdered at Kirk o' Field
 ↓
16 May 1568: Mary Stuart Lands at Workington
 ↓
Oct 1568: Conference of York Inquiries Open
 ↓
Nov 1569: Revolt of the Northern Earls

CORE DISCIPLINARY FOCUS

Dynastic Legitimacy & Northern Revolt •
 Exam Link: Q2 Causation / Q3 Essay

ENQUIRY 1

1H10/B4 • KEY TOPIC 1.1

The Situation on Elizabeth's Accession, 1558

Historical Enquiry: From crippling debt to looming foreign invasion: How did an inexperienced queen secure a divided and vulnerable England in 1558?

SECTION 1

SETTING THE SCENE: THE FRAGILE TUDOR PYRAMID & GOVERNANCE

[1.1] In the bitter freeze of November 1558, twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth Tudor sat beneath an ancient oak tree at Hatfield House when royal couriers galloped into the courtyard with momentous news: her half-sister, Queen Mary I, was dead. Elizabeth had survived five terrifying years in the mortal shadow of the executioner's block—interrogated in the Tower of London and placed under house arrest after Wyatt's rebellion. Now, she ascended the throne of an exhausted, anxious nation of three million people. Tudor society was organized by the **Great Chain of Being**—an immutable cosmic hierarchy ordained by God where every soul held an assigned station and owed unquestioned submission to their superiors. In the countryside, where nine out of ten English men and women lived, roughly fifty peerage noble families and the landed gentry owned the earth, ruling over yeoman farmers, tenant husbandmen, and landless labourers. In expanding market towns, wealthy merchants formed an urban elite above skilled guildsmen and destitute apprentices.

[1.2] Government centred upon the absolute personal sovereignty of the monarch, who claimed to rule by **Divine Right**. Yet the Crown commanded neither a standing army nor a salaried police force. Power was exercised through an intricate web of **royal patronage**. By dispensing peerage titles, land grants, knighthoods, and lucrative commercial monopolies, Elizabeth bound ambitious aristocrats to Crown service. Executive administration was conducted by the **Privy Council**—a tight inner circle of roughly nineteen trusted noblemen and statesmen meeting three times weekly to manage national defense, taxation, and international diplomacy. At its helm stood **Sir William Cecil**, whom Elizabeth appointed Principal Secretary on her accession day with prophetic words: *"I give you this charge that you shall be of my Privy Council and not respect my private will, but that which is best for the realm."*

[1.3] Statutory legislation and extraordinary taxation required the consent of **Parliament**, divided between the House of Lords (hereditary peers and bishops) and the House of Commons (landed gentry and wealthy burgesses). Unlike modern parliaments, the Tudor Parliament was an occasional instrument summoned only when the monarch required emergency **subsidies** (taxes)—gathering just nine times across Elizabeth's forty-five-year reign. In the shires, royal commands were executed by **Lord Lieutenants**, great nobles responsible for raising county militias, and unpaid **Justices of the Peace (JPs)**. These voluntary country gentry enforced statutory law, repaired highways, collected poor rates, and punished petty crime, providing the vital link between Whitehall directives and rural reality.

PRIMARY RECORD

SIXTEENTH-CENTURY ENGRAVING

c. 1580s

Source A: The Queen in Parliament



This contemporary engraving illustrates Elizabeth I enthroned above the Lords Spiritual, Lords Temporal, and Commons. While the monarch sat at the apex of government, parliamentary consent was constitutionally mandatory to grant extraordinary subsidies (taxation) and pass enforceable statutes.

Hinge Question: Why did Elizabeth jealously protect her "Royal Prerogative" against parliamentary debate, and which specific topics did she strictly forbid MPs from discussing?

SECTION 2

THE VIRGIN QUEEN: LEGITIMACY DOUBTS, MISOGYNY & THE MARRIAGE DILEMMA

[2.1] Elizabeth's accession was instantly stalked by existential doubts regarding her **legitimacy**. In the eyes of Catholic Europe and devout English Catholics, Elizabeth had no right to wear the crown. Henry VIII's 1533 marriage to Elizabeth's mother, Anne Boleyn, followed his unilateral divorce from Catherine of Aragon without papal annulment. Catholics regarded Henry's first marriage as indissoluble, meaning Elizabeth was born of an adulterous union. Following Anne Boleyn's beheading on charges of treason and adultery in 1536, Henry VIII himself pressured Parliament into passing the Second Succession Act, legally declaring Elizabeth illegitimate. Though Henry reinstated her in his 1544 will, Catholics insisted an act of human parliament could never overturn divine canon law. To Rome and Madrid, the true legitimate sovereign of England was Elizabeth's Catholic cousin, Mary, Queen of Scots.

[2.2] This dynastic vulnerability was intensified by deep sixteenth-century prejudice against female sovereigns. Drawing on biblical writings from Saint Paul, Renaissance Europe taught that women were intellectually, physically, and emotionally inferior to men, ordained to remain under male authority. A **'Queen Regnant'**—a female ruler exercising absolute executive command—was viewed as unnatural and alarming. The Scottish Calvinist preacher John Knox published a ferocious tract entitled *The First Blast of the Trumpet Against the Monstrous Regiment of Women*. The disastrous reign of Elizabeth's elder sister, Mary I, seemed to validate these fears: Mary's marriage to Philip II of Spain had dragged England into ruinous continental conflict, ignited Wyatt's armed rebellion, and subordinated English interests to the Spanish Habsburg empire.

[2.3] Consequently, the Privy Council and Parliament placed ferocious pressure upon Elizabeth to marry immediately and secure the Tudor Protestant line with a male heir. Yet marriage was a lethal constitutional trap. Marrying a foreign prince, such as Philip II of Spain or the Archduke Charles of Austria, risked transforming England into an exploited satellite of a Catholic super-state. Conversely, marrying an English

CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY • SPECIFICATION TERMS			KT 1.1 GLOSSARY
GREAT CHAIN OF BEING The rigid sixteenth-century social hierarchy established by God, dictating that every person held a fixed, unquestioned rank from monarch down to landless labourer.	ROYAL PATRONAGE The grant of titles, offices, lands, and trading monopolies by the monarch to secure political loyalty, manage court factions, and maintain nationwide obedience.	PRIVY COUNCIL A select body of approximately 19 trusted aristocratic advisers who met multiple times weekly to supervise day-to-day administration, finance, and foreign policy.	ROYAL PREROGATIVE Exclusive sovereign powers belonging solely to the Crown, including the right to decide foreign policy, declare war, and forbid parliamentary debate on religion or succession.

The Situation on Elizabeth's Accession, 1558 (Continued)

SECTION 3 THE EXCHEQUER IN RUIN: DEBT, DEBASEMENT & FISCAL AUSTERITY

[3.1] Beyond political intrigue, Elizabeth inherited a royal exchequer on the verge of bankruptcy. Decades of vainglorious French wars waged by Henry VIII, Edward VI's regents, and Mary I had bled the realm dry. In November 1558, Crown debt stood at an astronomical **£300,000**—a crippling liability when the monarch's ordinary annual revenue was barely £286,667. Most alarmingly, over £100,000 was owed to merchant bankers on the **Antwerp Exchange**, who demanded extortionate interest rates of 14 per cent. England stood in mortal danger of financial blackmail from the Spanish rulers of the Low Countries.

[3.2] Traditional royal revenues were severely depleted. To pay for past military campaigns, previous Tudor monarchs had sold off vast tracts of monastic land seized during the Dissolution of the Monasteries, permanently slashing Crown rental yields. To bridge the deficit, governments had repeatedly resorted to **debasement**—melting down silver shillings and reminting them with cheap copper. This reckless strategy shattered merchant confidence, sparked runaway inflation, quadrupled food prices, and caused real wages to collapse. The vital English cloth trade to Antwerp fell into catastrophic depression, throwing thousands of weavers into destitution.

[3.3] Without money, Elizabeth could neither hire foreign mercenary armies nor modernise decaying coastal fortifications. Yet calling Parliament to levy taxes was perilous: taxes provoked taxpayer unrest, and MPs routinely demanded religious concessions or royal marriage in return for subsidies. Under Cecil's direction, Elizabeth instituted ruthless financial austerity. She slashed royal household budgets, sold non-essential Crown lands for £120,000, collected ancient feudal dues, and overhauled customs collections. By 1574, through relentless fiscal discipline, Elizabeth achieved what seemed impossible: she eliminated all Crown debt and accumulated a £300,000 reserve in the Tower of London.

[4.1] Beyond England's shores, Elizabeth looked out upon a perilous continent dominated by Catholic superpowers. England was formally at war with France, dragged in by Mary I as Spain's imperial ally. In January 1558, French troops commanded by the Duke of Guise stormed and captured **Calais**, England's last continental possession held since the reign of Edward III in 1347. The loss shattered English pride: Calais was an essential commercial gateway for English wool exports and a strategic naval fortress guarding the English Channel. Mary I famously lamented on her deathbed that when she died, the word 'Calais' would be found engraved upon her heart.

[4.2] In April 1559, Elizabeth was forced to sign the humiliating **Treaty of Cateau-Cambr sis**, formally ending the Franco-Spanish war. France was permitted to retain Calais for eight years, after which it would be returned or France would pay 500,000 gold crowns—a clause everyone recognized as a diplomatic fiction masking permanent loss. Crucially, the treaty brought peace between Europe's two military giants: France and Spain. For the first time in sixty years, the Catholic superpowers were not fighting each other, creating the terrifying prospect of a united papal crusade to depose the young Protestant heretic queen in London.

[4.3] This danger was magnified on England's northern border by the historic **Auld Alliance** between France and Scotland. Scotland was ruled by the Catholic regent, Mary of Guise, who commanded heavily armed French garrisons along the English frontier. Her sixteen-year-old daughter, **Mary, Queen of Scots**, was married to the French Dauphin Francis. When King Henry II of France died in July 1559 and Francis ascended the throne as Francis II, Mary Stuart became Queen of France and Scotland simultaneously. Mary openly declared herself the true, rightful Queen of England, quartering the English royal arms onto her heraldic banners. England stood trapped in a lethal geopolitical pincer movement between French forces in Paris and French garrisons in Edinburgh.

KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

1520–1598



Sir William Cecil
PRINCIPAL SECRETARY OF STATE & QUEEN'S CHIEF MINISTER (LATER 1ST BARON BURGHLEY)

Elizabeth's most trusted political confidant, serving as Secretary of State from 1558 to 1572 and Lord High Treasurer from 1572 until his death. He masterminded the 1559 Religious Settlement, stabilized Crown finances, and coordinated state intelligence.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Appointed Principal Secretary on Elizabeth's accession day in November 1558, drafting her initial proclamations and governing directives.
- Steered the contentious Acts of Supremacy and Uniformity through a resistant House of Lords in the spring Parliament of 1559.
- Consistently urged Elizabeth to execute Mary, Queen of Scots, prioritize fiscal prudence, and construct a Protestant alliance against Catholic Spain.

CORE STRATEGIC MECHANISM

POLITICAL PRAGMATISM • 1558

The Marriage Dilemma: Pros vs. Cons of the Royal Match

In sixteenth-century Europe, marriage was the primary instrument for securing dynastic succession and cementing foreign alliances. Yet for Elizabeth, marriage posed an existential constitutional trap:

- Foreign Prince (e.g. Philip II of Spain, Prince Eric of Sweden):** Would provide military protection and diplomatic weight, but risked dragging England into costly foreign wars and subordinating national interests to a foreign crown (as occurred under Mary I).
- English Nobleman (e.g. Robert Dudley, Earl of Leicester):** Would avert foreign domination, but would inevitably trigger ferocious factional jealousy and aristocratic civil war among rival court families like the Howards and Cecils.
- The Celibate 'Virgin Queen':** Preserved sovereign independence and absolute political control, but left England without a direct Protestant heir, inviting dynastic plots and foreign invasion.

Strategic Legacy: Elizabeth exploited marriage negotiations as diplomatic bait for twenty-five years, stringing along foreign suitors to buy peace while permanently maintaining her sovereign independence.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			KT 1.1 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL: Identify two reasons why the loss of Calais under the Treaty of Cateau-Cambr�sis (1559) was viewed as a national humiliation.	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS: Explain why Henry VIII's divorce from Catherine of Aragon in 1533 created an ongoing crisis of legitimacy for Elizabeth in 1558.	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION: Evaluate whether Elizabeth's most urgent challenge on accession was financial insolvency or the Franco-Scottish military threat.	

ENQUIRY 2

1H10/B4 • KEY TOPIC 1.2

The 'Settlement' of Religion, 1559

Historical Enquiry: How successfully did Elizabeth's 1559 'Middle Way' reconcile intense religious divisions while establishing crown authority across England?

SECTION 1

A FRACTURED REALM: RELIGIOUS DIVISIONS & THE SEARCH FOR STABILITY

[1.1] In 1558, England stood on the brink of sectarian catastrophe. Over twenty-five violent years, the English people had suffered whiplash religious upheavals: Henry VIII's rupture with Rome in 1534, Edward VI's iconoclastic Calvinism (1547–1553), and Mary I's bloody Counter-Reformation (1553–1558), during which 284 Protestant men and women were burned alive at the stake for heresy. The realm was geographically and spiritually fractured. The North, the West Midlands, Lancashire, and Wales remained fiercely devoted to traditional Roman Catholicism, Latin masses, and the veneration of saints. Conversely, London, East Anglia, and the South-East contained vibrant, educated Protestant populations committed to continental Reformed theology.

[1.2] Compounding this volatility was the return of hundreds of **Marian exiles**—committed English Protestants who had fled Mary's burnings to live in Calvinist Geneva, Zurich, and Strasbourg. Returning home in November 1558, these zealous reformers expected Elizabeth to sweep away every trace of popery, abolish the hierarchy of bishops, and establish a pure Presbyterian church modelled on John Calvin's Geneva. Elizabeth herself was an educated Protestant, fluent in Greek and Latin, who revered the English Bible. However, unlike the returning exiles, she was a supreme political pragmatist: she understood that forcing radical Protestantism upon a conservative Catholic majority would provoke an immediate peasant rebellion and invite a foreign Catholic crusade.

[1.3] Elizabeth's overarching objective was political survival and civic peace. She sought to forge a **'Middle Way' (*Via Media*)**—a comprehensive church settlement that was firmly Protestant in its official doctrine and governance, but retained traditional Catholic ceremonial beauty, vestments, and episcopal hierarchy. By making church membership inclusive and refusing to police private conscience, Elizabeth sought to secure the outward obedience of conservative Catholics while anchoring England firmly within the Protestant world.

PRIMARY RECORD

STATUTE ROLL & TITLE PLATE

April 1559

Source A: The 1559 Act of Supremacy



The opening declaration of the 1559 Elizabethan settlement. By adopting the style "Supreme Governor of this Realm as well in all Spiritual or Ecclesiastical Things" rather than Henry VIII's "Supreme Head", Elizabeth offered deliberate conciliation to Catholic consciences while asserting total crown control over the Church.

Hinge Question: *What practical difference in theological perception was achieved by replacing the word "Head" with "Governor", and why was this crucial for securing moderate Catholic acquiescence?*

SECTION 2

THE LEGAL PILLARS: ACT OF SUPREMACY & ACT OF UNIFORMITY

CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY • SPECIFICATION TERMS			KT 1.2 GLOSSARY
SUPREME GOVERNOR The compromise title assumed by Elizabeth in the 1559 Act of Supremacy, appeasing Catholics who believed only Christ or the Pope could be Supreme Head of the Church.	ACT OF UNIFORMITY The 1559 law establishing a single, compulsory form of national worship, enforcing the Book of Common Prayer and imposing a 1-shilling fine on recusants.	RECUSANT A devout Catholic who refused to attend Church of England Sunday services, choosing to practice the Roman faith in secret and pay recurring financial penalties.	ROYAL INJUNCTIONS A set of 57 royal administrative instructions issued in 1559, ordering English Bibles in parishes, banning pilgrimages, and mandating preacher licenses.

[2.1] In the spring Parliament of 1559, Elizabeth and William Cecil steered two landmark statutes through ferocious Catholic opposition in the House of Lords. The first was the **Act of Supremacy (1559)**, which formally severed England's ties to the Papacy and restored Crown control over the Church. In a stroke of political genius, Elizabeth rejected Henry VIII's controversial title of 'Supreme Head'. Instead, she assumed the title of **'Supreme Governor'** of the Church of England. This calculated compromise reassured moderate Catholics, who believed only Christ or the Pope could be head of the Church, while appeasing radical Protestants who argued that scripture forbade a woman from claiming spiritual headship.

[2.2] The Act of Supremacy established an **Oath of Supremacy** mandatory for all public officials, judges, MPs, and clergymen, requiring them to swear fealty to the Queen as Supreme Governor. Any official refusing the oath was stripped of their office and livelihood. Crucially, while all but one of Mary's Catholic bishops refused the oath and were replaced with moderate Protestants, the vast majority of parish priests—roughly 9,000 across England—took the oath and kept their livings, guaranteeing administrative continuity across the countryside. The statute also created the Court of High Commission to investigate and punish religious deviance.

[2.3] The second pillar was the **Act of Uniformity (1559)**, which established a single, mandatory form of national worship. It enforced the universal use of an updated 1559 **Book of Common Prayer**, written in English. To reconcile conservative Catholics, the communion liturgy was crafted with deliberate, masterly ambiguity: the prayer book merged Cranmer's 1552 Protestant formula ("Take and eat this in remembrance that Christ died for thee") with traditional Catholic wording ("The body of our Lord Jesus Christ preserve thy body and soul"), permitting worshippers to interpret the bread and wine according to their own conscience. Church attendance on Sundays was compulsory: those who refused were branded **recusants** and fined **one shilling** per missed service (roughly a week's wages for a skilled labourer).

PRIMARY RECORD

OFFICIAL LITURGICAL TEXT

1559

Source B: The 1559 Book of Common Prayer



The mandatory prayer book compiled under the Act of Uniformity. It blended Cranmer's 1552 Protestant words of distribution ("Take and eat this in remembrance that Christ died for thee") with the 1549 Catholic phrasing ("The body of our Lord Jesus Christ preserve thy body and soul"), permitting both interpretations.

Hinge Question: *How did deliberate theological ambiguity regarding the Eucharist help prevent an immediate religious civil war in 1559?*

The 'Settlement' of Religion, 1559 (Continued)

SECTION 3 THE ROYAL INJUNCTIONS & MECHANISMS OF PARISH ENFORCEMENT

[3.1] To enforce the settlement at grassroots level, William Cecil issued fifty-seven **Royal Injunctions (1559)**. These detailed administrative orders instructed the clergy on parish operations. The Injunctions struck a careful balance: priests were commanded to preach the Royal Supremacy, denounce the Pope's usurped power, and ensure that every parish church purchased a large copy of the English Bible. To stamp out traditional Catholic superstition, pilgrimages to local holy wells were outlawed, fake relics were destroyed, and candle-burning before images was forbidden.

[3.2] However, Elizabeth inserted vital ceremonial concessions to soothe traditionalist parishioners. Church interiors retained an altar table rather than a plain wooden communion board; church music and organ-playing were encouraged; kneeling during prayer and bowing at the name of Jesus were maintained; and clergymen were permitted to marry only with the formal approval of their bishop and two JPs. Clergy were required to wear traditional liturgical dress: a white linen surplice during services and an outdoor black cope. Preaching was strictly policed: to prevent radical puritan or Catholic rabble-rousing, only ministers licensed by the Crown or a bishop were allowed to deliver sermons; unlicensed clergy were required to read approved homilies.

[3.3] Enforcement was carried out through nationwide episcopal **visitations**. In the summer of 1559, royal commissioners toured every diocese in England, inspecting church buildings, examining clergy qualifications, checking for English Bibles, and administering the Oath of Supremacy. Approximately 400 Marian priests who refused to conform were deprived of their posts, but the overwhelming majority conformed. Visitations were repeated every three to four years, ensuring that parish life steadily conformed to the statutory Elizabethan baseline.

KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

1504–1575



Matthew Parker
ARCHBISHOP OF CANTERBURY (1559–1575)

Appointed Archbishop of Canterbury by Elizabeth in 1559 to implement and defend the 'Middle Way'. A moderate Protestant scholar who had served as Anne Boleyn's chaplain, Parker provided intellectual stability and enforced clerical discipline during the Vestment Controversy.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Consecrated Archbishop in December 1559, supervising the restructuring of the Church of England after the Marian restoration.
- Drafted the Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion (1563), establishing the theological doctrine of the reformed Church of England.
- Issued the 1566 'Book of Advertisements' enforcing uniform clerical dress, firmly dismissing 37 London Puritan clergy who refused to comply.

SECTION 4 THE CHURCH OF ENGLAND AS AN ENGINE OF STATE AUTHORITY

[4.1] In sixteenth-century England, the Church was far more than a spiritual sanctuary; it was the state's supreme engine for nationwide social control, political indoctrination, and local administration. With no television, radio, or newspapers, the parish pulpit was the Crown's primary communication network. Every Sunday, thousands of congregations assembled to hear royal proclamations read aloud and recite prayers of thanks for the Queen's health and the preservation of the realm. Obedience to the monarch was preached as a direct commandment from God; rebellion was branded as the ultimate mortal sin.

[4.2] The Church operated its own powerful judicial apparatus known as **Church courts (consistory courts)**. These ecclesiastical tribunals held immense jurisdiction over everyday communal life. While royal common law courts dealt with property disputes and felonies, Church courts policed the moral fabric of society: prosecuting adultery, fornication, slander, witchcraft, public drunkenness, and failure to attend church. They also held legal monopolies over civil administrative functions: validating marriages, proving wills, administering probate, and regulating parish charities and schools.

[4.3] Furthermore, the parish church served as the social heartbeat of community life. Churchwardens organized seasonal festivals—such as May Day, harvest suppers, and Easter parish fairs—which reinforced communal solidarity and social cohesion. By preserving the traditional visual splendor of churches, rood screens, and musical liturgy, Elizabeth allowed ordinary peasants to experience the comforting familiarity of their ancestral rituals within a Protestant theological framework. For the first decade of her reign, this pragmatic compromise successfully prevented the catastrophic religious wars that were tearing France apart.

DISCIPLINARY SYNTHESIS

THE VIA MEDIA • 1559

The 1559 Settlement: Strategic Compromise Matrix
Elizabeth's 'Middle Way' was designed to establish national conformity while avoiding religious persecution that could trigger civil war:

PROTESTANT VICTORIES:

- English Book of Common Prayer mandatory in all parishes.
- Monasteries dissolved; Catholic shrines and pilgrimages banned.
- Royal Supremacy restored; papal authority formally abolished.
- Clergy permitted to marry with episcopal permission.

CATHOLIC CONCESSIONS:

- Title changed to 'Supreme Governor' (reassuring Catholic consciences).
- Priests wore traditional Catholic vestments (surplice/cope).
- Communion wording deliberately ambiguous regarding transubstantiation.
- Modest recusancy fine of 1 shilling per missed Sunday service.

Strategic Legacy: The Settlement prioritized political outward obedience over private conscience, successfully securing national order for a decade before foreign papal intervention escalated tensions.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			KT 1.2 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL: What specific change in royal title was introduced by the 1559 Act of Supremacy, and why was it significant?	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS: Explain why the Church of England served as the Crown's primary instrument of social control in rural parishes.	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION: Assess how far the 1559 Religious Settlement achieved its goal of creating a broadly accepted national church.	

ENQUIRY 3

1H10/B4 • KEY TOPIC 1.3

Challenge to the Religious Settlement

Historical Enquiry: To what extent did radical Puritan resistance and domestic Catholic dissent threaten the stability of the Elizabethan regime by 1570?

SECTION 1

THE PURITAN CHALLENGE: CRUCIFIXES, VESTMENTS & LAMBETH RESISTANCE

[1.1] While the 1559 Religious Settlement achieved broad national acceptance, it faced fierce ideological resistance from two unyielding extremes. From within Protestant ranks came the challenge of the **Puritans**—zealous reformers who believed Elizabeth’s ‘Middle Way’ was a cowardly, half-hearted compromise that retained the idolatrous ‘dregs of popery’. Puritans adhered to strict Calvinist theology: they believed in double predestination, rejected the authority of bishops, demanded a church governed by elected elders (Presbyterians), and insisted that any practice not explicitly mentioned in the Bible was a sinful invention of the Antichrist.

[1.2] The Puritan challenge erupted in two major flashpoints during the 1560s. The first was the **Crucifix Controversy**. Elizabeth insisted on keeping a silver crucifix and burning candles in her royal chapel, and ordered that every parish church retain a crucifix on the rood screen to comfort Catholic parishioners. Puritan bishops, led by Edmund Grindal and John Jewel, fiercely condemned crucifixes as idolatrous images that violated the Second Commandment. Several bishops threatened to resign en masse. Lacking educated Protestant clergymen to replace them, Elizabeth backed down and removed crucifixes from parish churches, though she stubbornly retained one in her private chapel.

[1.3] The second crisis was the **Vestment Controversy (1565–1566)**. Puritans rejected the mandatory white linen surplice, arguing that special priestly garments suggested ministers possessed supernatural powers to turn bread into Christ’s body. By 1565, many London preachers were refusing to wear the surplice, dressing in plain black gowns. Elizabeth ordered Archbishop Matthew Parker to enforce uniform dress. In 1566, Parker issued the ‘Book of Advertisements’ and summoned 110 London ministers to Lambeth Palace for a dress inspection. Thirty-seven ministers boldly refused to conform and were summarily dismissed from their livings. Despite their fury, Puritans remained politically loyal to Elizabeth because the only alternative—a Catholic monarch like Mary Stuart—was unthinkable.

PRIMARY RECORD

PAPAL DECREE & SEAL

25 February 1570

Source A: The Papal Bull Regnans in Excelsis



The official decree issued by Pope Pius V excommunicating Elizabeth Tudor. The bull declared: “We do out of the fullness of our Apostolic power declare the aforesaid Elizabeth to be a heretic and favourer of heretics... and we also declare her to be deprived of her pretended title to the aforesaid crown.”

Hinge Question: Why did Pope Pius V’s release of this bull in 1570 inadvertently undermine English Catholics by making religious loyalty synonymous with treason in the eyes of the Crown?

SECTION 2

THE NORTHERN CATHOLIC STRONGHOLD & RECUSANT RESISTANCE

[2.1] The Catholic challenge posed a far graver existential danger. In 1558, a substantial portion of the English population—and perhaps one-third of the nobility—remained devoted to Roman Catholicism. In northern counties such as Yorkshire, Durham, and Lancashire, Catholic influence was entrenched under the protection of ancient feudal families like the Percys (Earls of Northumberland) and the Nevilles (Earls of Westmorland). These magnates maintained private domestic chaplains who celebrated Latin masses in manor house attics, shielded secret priests, and quietly boycotted the local parish church.

[2.2] During the early 1560s, Elizabeth pursued a calculated policy of strategic leniency. She instructed county magistrates and JPs not to enforce recusancy fines with excessive severity, famously remarking that she had “no desire to make windows into men’s souls.” Elizabeth understood that pushing conservative Catholics into a corner would spark a peasant uprising. Moderate Catholics attended Church of England services to avoid fines and show outward loyalty, while privately practicing traditional devotions at home—a group historians describe as ‘church papists’.

[2.3] However, this delicate balance collapsed in the late 1560s. In 1566, Pope Pius V issued an official instruction forbidding English Catholics from attending Church of England services under pain of mortal sin. Simultaneously, the Catholic northern nobility grew intensely alienated: Elizabeth systematically bypassed ancient Catholic peers in favor of Protestant ‘new men’ like Cecil, while Protestant bishops aggressively cracked down on traditional northern customs. In November 1569, this resentment exploded into the armed **Revolt of the Northern Earls**, proving that domestic Catholicism could easily mobilize into armed rebellion against the Crown.

PRIMARY RECORD

CONTEMPORARY WOODCUT

c. 1566

Source B: The Elizabethan Clerical Vestments



Illustrating the white linen surplice and outdoor clerical cloak demanded by Archbishop Parker’s 1566 ‘Book of Advertisements’, Puritans reviled these garments as “popish rags” and “badges of Antichrist”, arguing that true ministers required no ceremonial hierarchy.

Hinge Question: Why did Elizabeth insist on strict clerical dress conformity when she was willing to tolerate private theological reservations?

CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY • SPECIFICATION TERMS			KT 1.3 GLOSSARY
VESTMENT CONTROVERSY The 1565–66 dispute where radical Puritan clergy refused to wear Catholic-style surplices and copes, resulting in the sacking of 37 London ministers by Archbishop Parker.	PURITAN A committed, radical Protestant who believed Elizabeth’s 1559 settlement was an incomplete compromise, seeking to completely purify the Church of popish ceremonies and bishops.	COUNTER-REFORMATION The aggressive global campaign launched by the Catholic Papacy and Council of Trent to stamp out Protestant heresy and reclaim England and Europe for Rome.	PAPAL BULL An official formal decree with a lead seal issued by the Pope. In 1570, ‘Regnans in Excelsis’ excommunicated Elizabeth and ordered her subjects to rebel.

Challenge to the Religious Settlement (Continued)

SECTION 3

THE COUNTER-REFORMATION & DOUAI'S CLANDESTINE MISSIONARIES

[3.1] The domestic Catholic threat was dramatically amplified by international developments. Across Western Europe, the Catholic Church launched the **Counter-Reformation**—a militant, highly coordinated campaign to stamp out Protestant heresy and reclaim lost territories for Rome. Spearheaded by the **Council of Trent (1545–1563)**, the Catholic hierarchy reformed Church abuses, standardized Latin theology, and established aggressive missionary orders like the Society of Jesus (Jesuits) to lead the spiritual reconquest.

[3.2] A central weapon in this campaign was the training of English Catholic priests in continental Europe. In 1568, an exiled English Catholic scholar, **Cardinal William Allen**, founded a specialized seminary college at Douai in the Spanish Netherlands. The college was established to train English Catholic youths in missionary theology and ordain them as seminary priests. From 1574 onwards, these priests were smuggled into England disguised as merchants, soldiers, and tutors. Sheltered in Catholic manor houses in specialized 'priest holes' built by Nicholas Owen, they traveled from village to village celebrating secret Latin masses, hearing confessions, and stiffening Catholic resistance.

[3.3] For the Elizabethan regime, the seminary priests were not mere religious ministers; they were viewed as hostile enemy agents sent by foreign Catholic superpowers. The Spanish Netherlands, lying directly across the English Channel, was garrisoned by 50,000 veteran Spanish troops under the brutal Duke of Alba, who was crushing the Dutch Protestant revolt. English ministers feared that seminary priests were preparing a domestic Catholic fifth column to assist a Spanish invasion fleet, transforming religious faith into a vital front of European geopolitics.

KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

1504–1572



Pope Pius V
BISHOP OF ROME & SUPREME PONTIFF OF THE ROMAN CATHOLIC CHURCH (1566–1572)

A fierce inquisitor and leader of the Counter-Reformation who hardened the Catholic Church's stance against Protestant monarchs. In 1570, he issued the fateful Papal Bull **Regnans in Excelsis**, decisively transforming English Catholic dissent into political treason.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Enforced the decrees of the Council of Trent, demanding total Catholic separation from Protestant church services and rituals.
- Issued the Papal Bull **Regnans in Excelsis** on 25 February 1570, declaring Elizabeth a heretic and excommunicating her from the Church.
- Explicitly absolved English Catholics of their oath of allegiance to the Crown, declaring that obeying Elizabeth was a mortal sin.

SECTION 4

THE THUNDERCLAP: REGNANS IN EXCELSIS & THE TREASON THRESHOLD

[4.1] The ultimate turning point in Elizabethan religious history occurred on 25 February 1570, when Pope Pius V issued the fateful Papal Bull ****Regnans in Excelsis****. This decree was an act of extraordinary spiritual aggression. The Pope officially excommunicated Elizabeth, castigating her as "the pretended Queen of England and the servant of crime." The bull declared Elizabeth a heretic, stripped her of her royal title, and released all English subjects from their oaths of fealty and obedience. Most dangerously, the Pope commanded English Catholics to disobey the Queen's laws under threat of excommunication.

[4.2] **Regnans in Excelsis** placed English Catholics in an impossible, tragic dilemma. Before 1570, a Catholic could remain a loyal subject of Queen Elizabeth while privately practicing their faith. After 1570, the Pope insisted that total loyalty to Rome required active disobedience to the Crown. Conversely, the Elizabethan government could no longer view recusancy as harmless personal eccentricity: anyone who acknowledged the Pope's authority was now, by definition, affirming that Elizabeth was not the lawful queen and that her deposition was a religious duty.

[4.3] Parliament responded decisively to the Papal Bull with the **Treasons Act (1571)**. This harsh statute made it high treason, punishable by hanging, drawing, and quartering, to declare that Elizabeth was not the lawful queen, to possess or publish papal bulls, or to convert anyone to the Roman Catholic faith. Anyone leaving England for more than six months without royal permission had their lands confiscated. The 1570 bull permanently shattered Elizabeth's policy of calculated leniency, forging an unbreakable link between English Protestantism and patriotic national survival.

CRITICAL TURNING POINT

PAPAL DIPLOMACY • 1570

The Mutation of Catholic Dissent: Faith to High Treason
Before 1570, Elizabeth tolerated Catholic recusants who quietly paid their 1-shilling fines, famously refusing to "make windows into men's souls." The 1570 Papal Bull shattered this compromise:

- The Papal Dilemma:** English Catholics were placed in an impossible moral double-bind: obedience to their Queen meant eternal damnation by the Pope, while obedience to the Pope made them traitors liable to horrific execution.
- The Treasons Act (1571):** Parliament responded swiftly by making it high treason to possess or publish papal bulls, describe Elizabeth as a heretic, or attempt to convert English subjects to Rome.
- Geopolitical Justification:** Foreign Catholic monarchs (Philip II of Spain and the French Guise faction) now possessed explicit spiritual sanction to assassinate Elizabeth and invade England.

Strategic Legacy: **Regnans in Excelsis** backfired on English Catholics: instead of rallying the populace to rebellion, it unified patriotic English Protestants and forced the Elizabethan state to criminalize Catholic practice.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			KT 1.3 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL:	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION:	
State two features of the 1566 Vestment Controversy between Elizabeth and Puritan clergy.	Explain why the 1570 Papal Bull fundamentally altered the legal position of English Catholics.	Evaluate whether the Puritan challenge or the Catholic challenge posed the greater danger to Elizabeth between 1559 and 1569.	

ENQUIRY 4

1H10/B4 • KEY TOPIC 1.4

The Problem of Mary, Queen of Scots, 1568–69

Historical Enquiry: Why did the arrival of Mary Stuart in 1568 create an insoluble dynastic crisis and a permanent Catholic figurehead against Elizabeth?

SECTION 1

THE SCOTTISH TRAGEDY: MURDER, SCANDAL & LOCHLEVEN ABDICATION

[1.1] In the late 1560s, a political earthquake in Scotland hurled the greatest dynastic crisis of Elizabeth’s reign across the English border. Mary Stuart, Queen of Scots, was Elizabeth’s first cousin once removed—the granddaughter of Henry VIII’s elder sister Margaret Tudor. Tall, charismatic, and cultured, Mary had been crowned Queen of Scotland at just six days old and raised at the glamorous French court as Dauphine and Queen Consort. Following the premature death of her French husband King Francis II in 1560, eighteen-year-old Mary returned to Edinburgh to rule a turbulent kingdom dominated by fierce, Protestant feudal nobles known as the Lords of the Congregation.

[1.2] Mary’s personal rule descended into violent melodrama and scandal. In 1565, she made the catastrophic decision to marry her handsome English Catholic cousin, Henry Stuart, **Lord Darnley**. The marriage quickly collapsed into drunken jealousy and political intrigue. In March 1566, Darnley and a cabal of Protestant lords burst into Mary’s private chambers at Holyroodhouse and savagely stabbed her Italian secretary, David Rizzio, fifty-six times before her eyes while she was six months pregnant. Eleven months later, on 10 February 1567, Darnley himself was murdered in Edinburgh: his lodgings at Kirk o’Field were obliterated by gunpowder barrels, and his strangled corpse was discovered in the adjacent garden.

[1.3] Public outrage reached boiling point when, barely three months later, Mary married the chief suspect in Darnley’s assassination, James Hepburn, **Earl of Bothwell**. Convinced of Mary’s complicity in regicide, Scotland’s Protestant lords rose in armed rebellion. They defeated Mary’s forces at Carberry Hill in June 1567, imprisoned her on an island fortress at **Lochleven Castle**, and forced her at swordpoint to abdicate the Scottish crown in favour of her thirteen-month-old infant son, who became King James VI under a Protestant regency. Bothwell fled into exile, dying insane in a Danish prison.

PRIMARY RECORD

FORMAL STATE PORTRAIT IN CAPTIVITY

c. 1578

Source A: The Sheffield Portrait of Mary Stuart



Painted during Mary’s prolonged captivity in England, showing the Scottish queen dressed in sombre black with an ornate rosary and crucifix prominently displayed at her waist. The portrait deliberately projected pious Catholic royalty, dynastic victimhood, and sovereign innocence.

Hinge Question: How did Mary Stuart’s continuous display of Catholic piety and royal symbols exacerbate the security paranoia of William Cecil and Francis Walsingham?

SECTION 2

THE FISHING BOAT AT WORKINGTON & THE DIPLOMATIC TRAP

[2.1] In May 1568, Mary pulled off a daring escape from Lochleven with the help of loyal servants, rallying a small army of six thousand supporters. However, on 13 May 1568, her forces were decisively routed by the Regent Murray’s army at the Battle of Langside near Glasgow. Terrified of falling back into the hands of her rebellious nobles, Mary made the fateful decision that would seal her doom: she fled south to the Solway Firth and, on **16 May 1568**, stepped into an open fishing boat and crossed the waters into England, landing at the obscure port of Workington in Cumberland.

[2.2] Mary’s arrival in England threw Elizabeth and William Cecil into total panic. Mary arrived expecting hospitality, sisterly royal solidarity, and an English army to restore her to her Scottish throne. Instead, her physical presence in England created an insoluble constitutional crisis. Under Catholic canon law, Mary possessed a stronger, purer claim to the English crown than Elizabeth, whom Catholics regarded as an illegitimate bastard. In England, Mary was an anointed monarch, a legitimate heir presumptive, and a living, magnetic focal point for every disgruntled Catholic noble in the realm.

[2.3] Elizabeth found herself impaled upon the horns of an impossible dilemma. She could not restore Mary to Scotland with English troops without alienating Scotland’s friendly Protestant regents and placing a hostile Catholic regime on her northern border. She could not allow Mary to seek refuge in France, where the Catholic Guise family would supply an invasion fleet to conquer England. Nor could she grant Mary freedom to travel within England, where she would immediately become the figurehead for northern Catholic rebellion. Elizabeth had Mary arrested and placed in secure custody at Carlisle Castle, beginning nineteen years of honourable English captivity.

PRIMARY RECORD

CONTESTED PRIMARY CORRESPONDENCE

Presented December 1568

Source B: Facsimile of a Casket Letter



A facsimile excerpt of the infamous letters produced by the Scottish Protestant Regent, the Earl of Murray, at the Conference of York. The letters purported to show Mary conspiring with Bothwell to blow up Kirk o’Field and assassinate her husband, Lord Darnley.

Hinge Question: Why did Elizabeth deliberately issue a verdict of “not proven” regarding the Casket Letters rather than declaring Mary guilty or innocent?

CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY • SPECIFICATION TERMS				KT 1.4 GLOSSARY
HEIR PRESUMPTIVE The person dynastically entitled to inherit the crown if the reigning monarch dies without direct legitimate offspring (Mary Stuart held this claim from 1558).	CASKET LETTERS A collection of eight French love letters and sonnets allegedly written by Mary Stuart to Bothwell, presented as evidence of her complicity in Darnley’s murder.	CONFERENCE OF YORK The 1568–69 judicial enquiry convened by Elizabeth to examine the Scottish charges against Mary Stuart, concluding with an ambiguous verdict of “not proven”.	ANOINTED MONARCH A ruler consecrated by holy oil in a church coronation, believed to rule by Divine Right, making their trial, deposition, or execution a grave spiritual sin.	

The Problem of Mary, Queen of Scots, 1568–69 (Continued)

SECTION 3

THE CONFERENCE OF YORK & THE CASKET LETTERS MYSTERY

[3.1] To establish legal justification for keeping an anointed foreign monarch under house arrest without trial, Elizabeth convened a judicial inquiry. Between October 1568 and January 1569, commissioners met at the **Conference of York** (later moved to Hampton Court and Westminster) to examine charges brought by the Scottish Protestant regents against their queen. The Regent Murray produced a small silver casket containing eight handwritten French letters and love sonnets, allegedly discovered in Bothwell’s baggage—the infamous **Casket Letters**. The letters purported to prove that Mary was violently in love with Bothwell and had actively lured Darnley to Kirk o’Field to be blown up.

[3.2] Mary fiercely denied the authenticity of the letters, insisting they were forged by Murray’s Protestant faction to justify her illegal deposition. She demanded the right to attend the conference in person to cross-examine her accusers and view the original documents. Elizabeth flatly refused, fearing Mary’s regal presence and forensic eloquence would sway the English commissioners. Crucially, the Scottish regents produced only copies, and the original letters subsequently vanished into history, leaving historians to debate their authenticity to this day.

[3.3] In January 1569, Elizabeth delivered a masterclass in political ambiguity, issuing an official verdict that *“nothing has been sufficiently proven”* against either side. Murray’s regency in Scotland was left intact, Darnley’s murder was left unresolved, and Mary was neither convicted of murder nor exonerated of treason. This calculated stalemate gave Elizabeth the legal pretext she desperately needed: because Mary was not cleared of murdering her husband, Elizabeth could refuse to receive her at court and justify keeping her in indefinite English custody.

KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

1542–1587



Mary Stuart (Mary, Queen of Scots)
QUEEN OF SCOTLAND (1542–1567) & CATHOLIC CLAIMANT TO THE ENGLISH THRONE

Elizabeth’s first cousin once removed, granddaughter of Henry VIII’s sister Margaret Tudor, and legitimate Catholic heir presumptive. Her arrival in England in 1568 in an open fishing boat triggered a permanent dynastic and security crisis that plagued Elizabeth for nearly two decades.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Claimed the English crown upon Mary I’s death in 1558, quartering the royal arms of England with those of France and Scotland.
- Forced to abdicate the Scottish throne at Lochleven Castle in 1567 following the scandalous murder of Darnley and marriage to Bothwell.
- Escaped to England in May 1568, where she remained in honourable English custody for 19 years until her execution at Fotheringhay in 1587.

SECTION 4

THE GOLDEN CAGE & THE GATHERING STORM OF REBELLION

[4.1] Following the Conference of York, Mary was transferred deep into the English Midlands, placed under the honourable custody of George Talbot, **Earl of Shrewsbury**. For the next fifteen years, Shrewsbury was forced to host Mary at his heavily fortified estates—Tutbury Castle, Sheffield Manor, and Chatsworth House. Mary lived in regal splendour, attended by thirty servants, private chaplains, French cooks, and embroiderers. Yet beneath the velvet luxury, Mary was a prisoner, her correspondence intercepted by Cecil’s secret agents and her visitors monitored with obsessive paranoia.

[4.2] Indefinite captivity transformed Mary from a discredited Scottish fugitive into a tragic Catholic martyr. For the English Catholic aristocracy, Mary represented the glorious hope of a restored Roman Catholic England. Her presence in the Midlands acted as a magnetic catalyst, galvanizing domestic conspirators, Spanish diplomats, and papal agents. Within months of her arrival, conservative English peers hatched a clandestine scheme to marry Mary to Thomas Howard, the Duke of Norfolk—the premier peer of England—to force Elizabeth to name Mary her successor.

[4.3] When Elizabeth discovered the Norfolk marriage plot in the autumn of 1569, Norfolk fled from court, and in November 1569, the Catholic Earls of Northumberland and Westmorland raised four thousand armed rebels in the **Revolt of the Northern Earls**. The rebels stormed Durham Cathedral, tore up the English Bible, and celebrated Latin mass before marching south to liberate Mary. Although royal armies crushed the rebellion, Mary Stuart’s presence had permanently shattered England’s internal peace, plunging the Elizabethan regime into an era of domestic plots, secret intelligence wars, and existential peril.

CONSTITUTIONAL IMPASSE

DIPLOMATIC CRISIS • 1568

Elizabeth’s Four Fatal Options Regarding Mary Stuart

When Mary landed at Workington in May 1568, Elizabeth faced four equally dangerous constitutional choices:

- Option A: Restore Mary to Scotland with an English Army:** Would uphold the divine right of anointed monarchs, but would alienate Scotland’s Protestant regents and replace friendly allies with a hostile Catholic regime.
- Option B: Exile Mary to France:** Would remove the immediate problem from England, but would allow Mary to rally French royal forces and organize a Catholic invasion fleet across the Channel.
- Option C: Grant Mary Free Passage in England:** Would enable her to tour the Catholic northern counties, meeting disgruntled nobility and actively rallying support to depose Elizabeth.
- Option D: Keep Mary in Indefinite English Captivity:** Avoided foreign war and immediate rebellion, but turned Mary into a permanent living martyr and figurehead for endless domestic plots.

Strategic Legacy: Elizabeth chose Option D. By keeping Mary captive under the Earl of Shrewsbury, she preserved temporary peace while unwittingly constructing the catalyst for nineteen years of continuous assassination plots.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			KT 1.4 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL: State two features of the 1568–69 Conference of York and the investigation into the Casket Letters.	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS: Explain why Mary Stuart’s arrival in England in May 1568 placed Elizabeth in an impossible diplomatic dilemma.	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION: Assess how far the problem of Mary, Queen of Scots destabilized Elizabethan England in the late 1560s.	

SYNOPTIC OVERVIEW

KEY TOPIC 1 MASTER SYNTHESIS • 1558–1569

Key Topic 1: Thematic Synoptic Matrix & Historiographical Debate

Disciplinary Synthesis: Evaluating Elizabeth's consolidation of royal authority across government, religious settlement, and dynastic security.

THEMATIC COMPARATIVE MATRIX • FOUR SPECIFICATION PILLARS			1558 CRISIS VS. 1569 REALITY
THEMATIC DIMENSION	THE CRISIS IN 1558	ELIZABETH'S STRATEGIC MECHANISM	THE BALANCE SHEET BY 1569
1. Royal Legitimacy & Gender	Viewed as illegitimate by Catholic Europe; 16th-century misogynist prejudice against female 'Queen Regnant'.	Assumed 'Supreme Governor' style; weaponized marriage negotiations as diplomatic bait; projected virgin majesty.	Sovereign independence preserved; court factions balanced; succession left dangerously unresolved.
2. Crown Finance & Economy	Exchequer £300,000 in debt; £100,000 owed to Antwerp at 14%; coin debasement causing rampant inflation.	Slashed household costs; sold £120,000 of Crown lands; recalled debased coinage and restored silver standard.	Antwerp debts cleared; royal credit restored; financial independence minimized reliance on Parliament.

THE HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE • INTERPRETATIONS OF THE 1559 SETTLEMENT

HISTORICAL SCHOLARSHIP

THE TRADITIONAL WHIG VIEW (SIR JOHN NEALE, 1957):

Elizabeth was a determined moderate Protestant who sought a conservative settlement similar to Henry VIII's church. However, she was politically coerced into a more radical Protestant settlement than she wished by a well-organized, vocal faction of returned Marian exiles in the House of Commons known as the 'Puritan Choir'. In Neale's view, the Middle Way was Elizabeth's triumphant masterstroke of political pragmatism.

THE REVISIONIST VIEW (CHRISTOPHER HAIGH / NORMAN JONES, 1982):

Revisionists completely debunked Neale's 'Puritan Choir' thesis. Norman Jones proved that the real legislative opposition in 1559 came from Marian Catholic bishops and conservative peers in the House of Lords. Christopher Haigh argues that the settlement did not create permanent religious peace; it alienated devout Catholics and Puritans alike, acting as a fragile political armistice that merely delayed sectarian rebellion until 1569.

Hinge Question for Class Discussion:

Did Elizabeth's religious settlement succeed because of its deliberate theological ambiguity, or did that very ambiguity sow the seeds for the Catholic rebellions of 1569–1570?

KEY CHRONOLOGY: SIX CAUSAL TURNING POINTS (1558–1570)			CRITICAL PROGRESSION
17 Nov 1558 • Accession of Elizabeth I Mary I dies; 25-year-old Elizabeth succeeds; appoints William Cecil Principal Secretary at Hatfield House.	29 Apr 1559 • Acts of Supremacy & Uniformity Parliament passes core legislation establishing the Elizabethan Church and Book of Common Prayer.	6 Jul 1560 • Treaty of Edinburgh French and English troops withdraw from Scotland; Protestant lords consolidate rule, neutralizing northern threat.	
26 Mar 1566 • Parker's Book of Advertisements Archbishop Parker enforces vestments; 37 London Puritan ministers dismissed at Lambeth Palace.	16 May 1568 • Mary Stuart Lands at Workington Mary escapes Lochleven, crosses Solway Firth in a fishing boat, seeking English refuge and touching off dynastic crisis.	Jan 1569 • Conference of York Stalemate Inquiry into Casket Letters concludes with verdict of "not proven"; Mary held in honourable English captivity.	

THEMATIC COMPARATIVE MATRIX • SIX SPECIFICATION PILLARS			1558 CRISIS VS. 1569 REALITY
THEMATIC DIMENSION	THE CRISIS IN 1558	ELIZABETH'S STRATEGIC MECHANISM	THE BALANCE SHEET BY 1569
1. Royal Legitimacy & Gender	Viewed as illegitimate by Catholic Europe; 16th-century misogynist prejudice against female 'Queen Regnant'.	Assumed 'Supreme Governor' style; weaponized marriage negotiations as diplomatic bait; projected virgin majesty.	Sovereign independence preserved; court factions balanced; succession left dangerously unresolved.
2. Crown Finance & Economy	Exchequer £300,000 in debt; £100,000 owed to Antwerp at 14%; coin debasement causing rampant inflation.	Slashed household costs; sold £120,000 of Crown lands; recalled debased coinage and restored silver standard.	Antwerp debts cleared; royal credit restored; financial independence minimized reliance on Parliament.
3. Religious Compromise	Realm deeply fractured: Catholic North/West vs radical Protestant South-East and returning Marian exiles.	1559 'Middle Way': Acts of Supremacy & Uniformity, ambiguous Book of Common Prayer, 1s recusancy fine.	Broad outward conformity achieved for a decade; puritan complaints contained; Catholic resistance festering.

French troops expelled from Scotland.

THE HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE • THREE INTERPRETATIONS OF THE 1559 SETTLEMENT

HISTORICAL SCHOLARSHIP

1. TRADITIONAL WHIG (SIR JOHN NEALE, 1957):

Elizabeth wanted a conservative Henrician settlement, but was coerced into a radical Protestant settlement by an organized, vocal faction of returned Marian exiles in the Commons known as the 'Puritan Choir'. The Middle Way was Elizabeth's pragmatic masterstroke.

2. REVISIONIST (HAIGH & JONES, 1982):

Debunked Neale's thesis: real legislative opposition came from Catholic bishops in the Lords, not Puritans in the Commons. The settlement was an enforced political armistice that alienated devout believers on both wings, merely delaying sectarian revolt until 1569.

3. POST-REVISIONIST (COLLINSON & DORAN, 1994):

The Elizabethan polity operated as a 'Monarchical Republic'. Councillors like Cecil viewed the 1559 settlement as a national security fortress, prepared to exercise corporate political authority to protect Protestantism from dynastic Catholic decapitation.

Hinge Question for Class Discussion:

Did Elizabeth's religious settlement succeed because of its deliberate theological ambiguity, or did that very ambiguity sow the seeds for the Catholic rebellions of 1569–1570?

KEY CHRONOLOGY: EIGHT CAUSAL TURNING POINTS (1558–1570)			CRITICAL PROGRESSION
17 Nov 1558 • Accession Mary dies; 25-year-old Elizabeth succeeds; appoints Cecil Principal Secretary.	15 Jan 1559 • Coronation Westminster ceremony balances Latin Catholic ritual with English scripture.	29 Apr 1559 • Settlement Acts Acts of Supremacy & Uniformity establish Church of England & Prayer Book.	6 Jul 1560 • Treaty of Edinburgh French withdraw from Scotland; northern border stabilized under Protestants.
1563 • Thirty-Nine Articles Convocation codifies national Church doctrine, fusing Calvinism with bishops.	26 Mar 1566 • Advertisements Parker enforces vestments; 37 London Puritan ministers dismissed.	16 May 1568 • Mary at Workington Mary escapes Lochleven; seeks English refuge, unleashing dynastic crisis.	25 Feb 1570 • Regnans in Excelsis Pius V excommunicates Elizabeth; frees subjects from loyalty, spurring treason.

COMPARATIVE POLICY SUCCESS EVALUATION • 1558–1569			CRITERIA-LED VERDICT
1. FISCAL: HIGH SUCCESS Crown debt reduced from £300,000 to	2. RELIGIOUS: MODERATE Avoided immediate religious civil war;	3. FOREIGN: MODERATE Treaty of Edinburgh expelled French	4. DYNASTIC: LOW SUCCESS Refusal to marry or name an heir left

SYNOPTIC VERDICT • THE DYNAMICS OF EARLY ELIZABETHAN SURVIVAL

Between 1558 and 1569, Elizabeth transformed an impoverished, divided nation into a remarkably stable sovereign state. Her greatest triumph was fiscal discipline and political ambiguity: by slashing Crown expenditures and creating an inclusive religious settlement, she deprived foreign Catholic powers of an excuse for invasion. However, her deliberate refusal to marry or name a successor left the Tudor dynasty hostage to fortune, ensuring that Mary Stuart's arrival in 1568 ignited the very sectarian rebellions Elizabeth had spent a decade attempting to avert.

EXAM MASTERCLASS

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 OPTION B4 • 1H10/B4

Edexcel Paper 2: Examination Strategy & Exemplar Model Answers

Official Exam Blueprint: Deconstructing Question 1(a) & 1(b) Features [4m], Question 2 Causation [12m], and Question 3 Evaluative Essay [16m + 4 SPaG].

QUESTION 1(A) & 1(B): DESCRIBE ONE FEATURE OF... [2 MARKS EACH • 4 MARKS TOTAL • 6 MINS]

Q1(a): Describe one feature of the 1559 Act of Supremacy. [2 marks]
Model Answer: One feature was Elizabeth's assumption of the title '**Supreme Governor**' of the Church of England rather than 'Supreme Head'. *[1 mark for valid feature]* This was a deliberate political compromise designed to pacify Catholics who believed only the Pope could head the Church, while reassuring Protestants who objected to a female sovereign claiming spiritual headship. *[1 mark for supporting historical detail]*

Q1(b): Describe one feature of Church of England visitations in 1559. [2 marks]
Model Answer: One feature was that teams of royal commissioners toured every parish to administer the mandatory **Oath of Supremacy** to all clergymen. *[1 mark for valid feature]* While approximately 400 Marian Catholic priests refused the oath and were deprived of their livings, the vast majority—roughly 9,000 parish priests—swore the oath, securing national continuity. *[1 mark for supporting historical detail]*

Examiner Warning: Candidates frequently lose time writing detailed explanations or consequences. For 2-mark feature questions, state the feature directly and add one precise factual statistic, date, or name. Do not explain why it happened!

Formula: 1 Mark Valid Feature + 1 Mark Supporting Detail (0 Explanation/Consequences)

QUESTION 2: EXPLAIN WHY... [12 MARKS • 18 MINUTES]

Formula: 3 Full PEEL Paragraphs (2 Stimulus + 1 Own Knowledge) + Explicit Causal Connectives

Exam Prompt: Explain why the arrival of Mary, Queen of Scots in England in 1568 caused serious problems for Elizabeth I. You may use: (1) Dynastic claims to the throne, (2) The Catholic northern nobility. [12 marks]

PEEL Paragraph 1 (Dynastic Legitimacy & Alternative Monarch): One major reason Mary's arrival created a severe crisis was her undeniable dynastic claim to the English crown as Henry VII's great-granddaughter. Because devout Catholics viewed Elizabeth as illegitimate due to Henry VIII's unannulled divorce from Catherine of Aragon, Mary was regarded across Catholic Europe as the rightful Queen of England. *Consequently*, her physical presence on English soil transformed theoretical dynastic claims into an immediate, mortal threat. Mary served as a living sovereign figurehead around whom disaffected Catholics could rally to depose Elizabeth through assassination or foreign-backed invasion.

PEEL Paragraph 2 (Domestic Feudal Discontent & Northern Earls): Furthermore, Mary's arrival directly inflamed domestic aristocratic rebellion among the conservative Catholic nobility of northern England. Ancient peers such as Charles Neville, Earl of Westmorland, and Thomas Percy, Earl of Northumberland, were already intensely alienated by Elizabeth's centralizing Protestant government, which had stripped them of traditional border offices and royal patronage in favour of Protestant southerners like William Cecil. *As a direct result*, Mary's arrival in Cumberland provided these desperate nobles with an anointed Catholic claimant, precipitating the armed 1569 Revolt of the Northern Earls.

PEEL Paragraph 3 (Own Knowledge: Foreign Encirclement & The Diplomatic Trap): Crucially, Mary's presence placed Elizabeth in an impossible international diplomatic trap. Mary possessed powerful French royal connections through her mother's Guise family and was supported by Philip II of Spain. Elizabeth could neither restore Mary to Scotland with English troops without alienating the Protestant Scottish regents who secured England's northern frontier, nor execute an anointed queen without provoking a unified Catholic crusade against England. *Therefore*, holding Mary in indefinite captivity under the Earl of Shrewsbury transformed England into a permanent magnet for foreign invasion and papal conspiracy.

QUESTION 3: EVALUATIVE ESSAY [16 MARKS + 4 SPAG • 25 MINUTES]

Level 4 Standard: 3 Balanced Factors + Criteria-Led Sustained Judgement

Exam Prompt: "The threat of foreign invasion was the most serious problem facing Elizabeth I between 1558 and 1569." How far do you agree? Explain your answer. You may use: (1) The loss of Calais (1558), (2) The arrival of Mary, Queen of Scots (1568).

FACTOR 1: FOREIGN INVASION (AGREE)
Loss of Calais in 1558 left England's southern coast defenceless; Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis united France and Spain; French troops in Scotland under Mary of Guise threatened immediate invasion.

FACTOR 2: CROWN DEBT & FINANCE (COUNTER)
£300,000 Crown debt with £100,000 owed to Antwerp at 14% interest meant Elizabeth could not afford a standing army, build fortifications, or finance war without risking tax rebellions.

FACTOR 3: DYNASTIC LEGITIMACY & MARY (COUNTER)
Mary Stuart's arrival in 1568 provided a living Catholic figurehead who quartered the English arms, directly sparking the 1569 Northern Revolt and domestic treason.

EXEMPLAR LEVEL 4 CONCLUSION (CRITERIA-LED SUSTAINED JUDGEMENT):
"In conclusion, while the threat of foreign invasion was the most catastrophic potential danger, financial insolvency was Elizabeth's most serious foundational problem between 1558 and 1569. When assessing severity by the criterion of foundational constraint, without economic solvency Elizabeth could neither field an army to defend against foreign invaders nor enforce her religious settlement in the conservative north. Crown debt constrained every diplomatic, marital, and military decision of her first decade. Furthermore, while the foreign threat was largely neutralized by 1560 through the Treaty of Edinburgh and the outbreak of the French Wars of Religion, Mary Stuart's arrival in 1568 transformed the crisis from an external danger into an active internal conspiracy. Therefore, while foreign invasion was the most visible external peril, the underlying £300,000 debt was the root weakness that made all other problems existential."

SPaG Masterclass (+4 Marks): Spell technical terms accurately (*recusancy, sovereignty, prerogative, Marian exiles*). Use complex analytical sentences with causal connectives. **4/4 SPaG TARGET**

Early Elizabethan England, 1558–1588 • Edexcel Examination Strategy

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KEY TOPIC 1 CHRONOLOGICAL SEQUENCE • TURNING POINTS (1558–1570)			CAUSAL PROGRESSION
DATE	PIVOTAL EVENT	HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CAUSAL CONSEQUENCE	
17 Nov 1558	Accession of Elizabeth I	Mary I dies; 25-year-old Elizabeth succeeds; inherits £300,000 Crown debt and French war.	
Nov 1558	Appointment of William Cecil	Cecil named Principal Secretary, initiating a 40-year partnership of fiscal caution and intelligence.	
15 Jan 1559	Westminster Coronation	Elizabeth crowned in Westminster Abbey; balances Latin Catholic ritual with English scripture.	
2 Apr 1559	Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis	Peace between France and Spain; England formally surrenders Calais after two centuries of rule.	
29 Apr 1559	Acts of Supremacy & Uniformity	Elizabeth assumes title 'Supreme Governor'; English Prayer Book made compulsory; 1s recusancy fine.	
Summer 1559	Royal Injunctions & Visitations	57 injunctions enforce Protestant practice; royal commissioners deprive ~400 non-conforming clergy.	
6 Jul 1560	Treaty of Edinburgh	French troops withdraw from Scotland; northern border stabilized under Scottish Protestant lords.	
1563	Thirty-Nine Articles	Convocation establishes theological doctrine of Church of England, fusing Calvinism with bishops.	
26 Mar 1566	Book of Advertisements	Archbishop Parker enforces clerical dress; 37 London Puritan ministers dismissed at Lambeth Palace.	
1567	Duke of Alba Arrives in Netherlands	Philip II dispatches 50,000 Spanish veterans to crush Dutch revolt, creating invasion threat across Channel.	
1568	Douai Seminary Founded	Cardinal William Allen establishes Douai College in Flanders to train missionary priests for England.	
16 May 1568	Mary Stuart Lands at Workington	Mary flees Scotland in an open fishing boat; placed in honourable English custody for 19 years.	
Oct 1568–Jan 1569	Conference of York	Inquiry into Darnley's murder and Casket Letters concludes 'not proven', justifying Mary's captivity.	
25 Feb 1570	Papal Bull Regnans in Excelsis	Pope Pius V excommunicates Elizabeth; frees subjects from loyalty; turns Catholicism into treason.	

KEY DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY

- **Great Chain of Being:** Rigid 16th-century divine hierarchy placing the monarch at the apex of all social ranks down to labourers.
- **Royal Prerogative:** Sovereign powers exclusively reserved for the Crown, including marriage, succession, religion, and foreign policy.
- **Supreme Governor:** Elizabeth's title under the 1559 Act of Supremacy, pacifying Catholic consciences while asserting Crown supremacy.
- **Recusant:** A devout Catholic who refused to attend Church of England Sunday services, paying the statutory 1-shilling fine.
- **Royal Injunctions:** 57 administrative directives in 1559 ordering English Bibles, licensing preachers, and banning pilgrimages.
- **Vestment Controversy:** 1565–66 Puritan clash over Catholic-style surplices, resulting in 37 London ministers being sacked.
- **Douai Seminary:** Training college founded in Flanders (1568) by William Allen to prepare Catholic missionary priests to enter England.
- **Papal Bull (1570):** *Regnans in Excelsis* issued by Pope Pius V excommunicating Elizabeth and ordering subjects to depose her.

EDExcel PAPER 2 EXAM FRAMEWORK & MODELS

32 MARKS TOTAL • 50 MINS

Q1(a) & Q1(b): Describe ONE feature of... [2 + 2 = 4 Marks • 6 Mins]

Model: "Describe one feature of the 1559 Act of Supremacy."
Formula: 1 mark valid feature + 1 mark supporting historical detail (0 explanation).

Q2: Explain why... [12 Marks • 18 Mins]

Model: "Explain why the arrival of Mary Stuart caused problems for Elizabeth in 1568."
Formula: 3 PEEL paragraphs (2 stimulus + 1 own knowledge) linked with causal connectives.

Q3: Evaluative Essay [16 Marks + 4 SPaG • 25 Mins]

Model: "'The threat of foreign invasion was the main problem facing Elizabeth in 1558.' How far do you agree?"
Formula: 3 balanced analytical paragraphs + criteria-led sustained conclusion.

ASSESSMENT OBJECTIVE 1 (AO1 • 50%): Demonstrate knowledge and understanding of the key features and characteristics of the period studied, including precise dates, statistics, and statutory legislation.	ASSESSMENT OBJECTIVE 2 (AO2 • 50%): Explain and analyse historical events and periods studied using second-order concepts (cause, consequence, change, continuity, and reaching sustained historical judgements).
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KEY TOPIC 1 KNOWLEDGE QUIZ & FLASHCARDS

Scan the QR code with any smartphone or tablet camera to launch the interactive, self-marking retrieval bank for Key Topic 1. Test your rapid recall across the Accession Crisis, 1559 Settlement, Vestment Controversy, Douai Seminaries, and Mary Stuart with instant model answers and scoring.

• 20 Specification Recall Questions

• Instant Self-Marking & Explanations

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SCAN FOR MOBILE QUIZ

Paper 2: Early Elizabethan England, 1558–1588 • Key Topic 1 Specification Review Index

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